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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Boom in AI raises fears of a painful pop ahead

Economic growth largely driven by Big Tech’s bets on technology’s promise

BY GERRIT DE VYNCK

SAN FRANCISCO — Spending by consumers has dominated the American economy for decades, usually the largest driver of economic growth. But in the first half of this year, spending by companies on artificial intelligence rivaled consumers as the primary engine of the nation’s economic expansion.

That startling shift is one of many recent examples of AI’s increasingly outsized role in propelling up U.S. economic fortunes — and a sign, some fear, of a soon-to-pop speculative bubble that could cause widespread financial pain.

“We’re seeing a massive AI investment boom that is driving a number of statistics to explode,” said Gregory Daco, chief economist at strategy consulting firm EY-Parthenon.

The stock market is near record highs, driven by the shares of technology companies that have put AI at the center of their business strategies. Last week, the United States reported that the economy expanded at a rate of 1.6 percent in the first half of the year, with most of that growth driven by AI spending.

Without AI investment, growth would have been at about a third of that rate, according to

SEE AI ON A15

Bad Bunny’s halftime slot is generating MAGA fury

Puerto Rican artist set to perform at Super Bowl has criticized Trump

BY SABRINA RODRIGUEZ

“Make America Great Again” influencers are furious with the National Football League — again — after the sports league announced Sunday that Bad Bunny, the superstar Puerto Rican recording artist, would headline its Super Bowl LX halftime show in Santa Clara, California, on Feb. 8.

The NFL, which has a bipartisan fan base, has been leery of entering the culture wars since President Donald Trump’s first term, when the league largely capitulated to his demand that it prevent players from kneeling on the sidelines during the national anthem to protest racial inequality and police brutality.

Bad Bunny’s critics have zeroed in on his criticism of Trump’s agenda, his exclusively Spanish-language lyrics, his gender-fluid fashion choices and his comments in a recent interview sharing that part of the reason he was not touring his latest album, “Debí Tirar Más FOTOS,” in the U.S. mainland was out of concern his concerts would become a target for Immigration and Customs Enforcement raids.

The NFL did not respond to a request for comment.

Bad Bunny, whose full name is Benito Antonio Martínez Ocasio,

SEE BAD BUNNY ON A4



ALEX WONG/GETTY IMAGES

Trump, Hegseth address military leaders

Rare, politically charged summit becomes forum to tout partisan agenda

BY DAN LAMOTHE, TARA COPP AND ALEX HORTON

Hundreds of the U.S. military’s top leaders listened in silence to highly partisan addresses from President Donald Trump and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth on Tuesday, with each harshly criticizing their predecessors and hyping their political objectives during an extraordinary exhibition of both men’s grievances.

The event, organized by Hegseth’s team at the Pentagon, summoned generals and admi-



ANDREW HARNIK/POOL/REUTERS

Military officers, at top, gathered Tuesday at Marine Corps Base Quantico in Virginia, where they heard speeches from President Donald Trump and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, above.

The Take: 1990 is an odd time to yearn for in the military. **A7**

Whistleblowing: Secretary vows to overhaul system. **A7**

Trump’s message: Generals should fight “war from within.” **A8**

rals from their command posts throughout the world to Marine Corps Base Quantico, in Virginia, about 30 miles south of Washington. Gen. Dan Caine, Trump’s hand-selected chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, told attendees in his opening comments that the event was an “unprecedented opportunity and honor” for the assembled senior officers and their top enlisted advisers to hear directly from the military’s civilian leadership.

Trump, with an eager Cabinet official now in charge at the Pentagon, has repeatedly and unapologetically trampled on long-standing norms intended to keep the American military beyond the grasp of partisan politics. But Tuesday’s presentation stood apart as perhaps the most explicit demonstration to date of this administration’s wholesale

SEE GENERALS ON A8

Trump administration illegally targeted pro-Palestinian protesters, judge rules

BY JOANNA SLATER

The Trump administration’s push earlier this year to arrest and deport international students for their pro-Palestinian activism was illegal, a federal judge ruled Tuesday, calling the crackdown a “truly scandalous and unconstitutional suppression of free speech.”

In a sweeping rebuke, U.S. District Judge William Young in Boston said that the Department of Homeland Security and the State Department targeted noncitizens “for speaking out” with the “goal of tamping down pro-Palestinian student protests and terrorizing similarly situated” students.

“We are not, and we must not become, a nation that imprisons

and deports people because we are afraid of what they have to tell us,” Young wrote.

Young, who was appointed to the federal bench by President Ronald Reagan, described the case as “perhaps the most important ever to fall within the jurisdiction of this district court.”

In Tuesday’s decision, Young decried the Trump administra-

tion’s conduct in striking terms, quoting Reagan’s declaration that freedom must “be fought for and defended constantly by each generation.”

Young also said that President Donald Trump was unlikely to change course, even in the face of blistering criticism from a federal judge. Trump “simply ignores it all when he takes it into his head

to act,” Young wrote. Still, the president is not “entirely lawless,” he added.

The judge said he would decide upon an appropriate remedy for the Trump administration’s conduct after a future hearing.

Liz Huston, a spokeswoman for the White House, said in an email that Tuesday’s order was

SEE PROTESTERS ON A2



ARLETTE BASHIZI/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Bertha Kolongosola outside her family’s home in Lubumbashi, Democratic Republic of Congo. They moved there to get away from reminders of her daughter Suza Kenyaba, who died in February at age 5.

USAID pause snared lifesaving drugs

Children died waiting for malaria and HIV treatments amid supply chain disruptions

Ever ravaged the body of 5-year-old Suza Kenyaba as she sweated and shivered on a thin mattress in a two-room clinic in the Democratic Republic of Congo. The pigtailed girl who liked pretty dresses was battling malaria and desperately needed medication that could save her life.

That medication, already purchased by a U.S.-taxpayer-funded program, was tantalizingly close — a little more than seven miles away. But it hadn’t reached the clinic where Suza was being treated because President Donald Trump’s suspension of foreign aid had thrown supply chains into chaos.

The injections Suza needed had traveled thousands of miles

This article is by Meg Kelly, Joyce Sohym Lee, Rael Ombuor, Sarah Blaskey, Andrew Ba Tran, Artur Galocha, Eric Lau and Katharine Houvrel

to the Central African nation, USAID and other records show, only to be stranded in a regional distribution warehouse in the same city where she was gasping for air.

Less than a week after her symptoms began, Suza was dead. Congolese government data shows that in Suza’s province, deaths caused by malaria nearly tripled in the first half of this year.

Parts of the U.S. Agency for International Development’s

SEE AID ON A12

IN THE NEWS

Military callout Louisiana’s Republican governor has asked the Pentagon to send National Guard troops into New Orleans and Baton Rouge, despite falling crime rates. **A3**

Gaza peace plan Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu attempts to sell Trump’s proposal to a skeptical right wing. **A11**

THE NATION Florida officials voted to donate land in Miami for Donald Trump’s presidential library. **A3**
A second immigrant shot in the attack on an ICE field office in Dallas has died. **A4**

THE WORLD In Germany, there was only one way to settle the history of bratwurst: with a boxing match. **A9**
Shops closed and flights were grounded as Afghanistan’s internet blackout continued. **A10**

THE ECONOMY DoorDash’s first built-from-scratch autonomous delivery robot is designed to ferry cargo through suburbia. **A14**
Michelle Singletary asks: If you had only a year to live, upending your best-laid plans, would you still be a penny pincher? **A15**

STYLE A reboot of “Phantom of the Opera” is an immersive, sensual experience in a five-story former art supply shop. **B1**

SPORTS A Princeton basketball standout is taking a year off to focus on his degree — and grow his earning potential. **B7**

THE REGION D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser announced several initiatives intended to boost the city’s economy amid headwinds. **B13**

FOOD D.C.’s restaurant class of 2015 brought new cuisines, revived neighborhoods and raised the city’s national profile.

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